One Question Too Soon

Companion Workbook

The Rotten Fencepost™ Principle

by Kahu Phil Stephens

Rotten Fencepost Publishing

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This workbook accompanies the teaching "One Question Too Soon" and the wider Rotten Fencepost Principle. You are welcome to use it for your own reflection and to share it with anyone who might need it.

Introduction

Aloha. Have you ever finally figured out what was wrong in your life, did something about it, and then six months later were right back in the same place?

You looked at what was happening and said, "There it is. That's the problem." And maybe you were right. But what if what you found really was a problem, but it wasn't the whole problem?

This workbook will not tell you what is underneath your problem - only you can find that. It offers the same honest questions taught in the video, in the order you would ask them sitting across the table.

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The Fence Post, One Layer Deeper

When a fence keeps failing, a paniolo can tighten the wire, replace the staples and straighten everything up. But if the post underneath is rotten, you are repairing what you can see and leaving the real problem in the ground.

There is a deeper danger: we can look deeper and still stop too soon. A post is leaning - that is a fact. It is rotten below the ground - that is another fact. "I found it." Maybe. But why did it rot? Maybe the ground stays wet. Maybe the drainage is wrong. And what if nothing was wrong with the post at all? A perfectly good post can still fail if the ground cannot support it.

A fact can be true without being the whole truth.

Pick One Problem

Do not start with the biggest problem in your life. Pick one problem that keeps coming back - something you have fixed before.

The problem that keeps coming back:

What I can actually see (the facts - only what I know for sure):

What I am assuming:

What I have already decided is causing this:

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One More Question

Look at your answer without condemning yourself and without immediately blaming somebody else. Then ask one more question: what if I stopped looking one step too soon?

Why did that happen? (Go one layer underneath what you wrote above.)

And underneath that - what is it standing on?

Is it possible there is nothing wrong with me or the thing I keep fixing, and that it is planted in ground that cannot support it?

Five Places to Look Underneath

Money. You made a budget and ended up right back where you started. Why are you spending? What happens when you are stressed? What did you learn about money growing up? Are there family expectations draining what you have? Or does your income simply not support your basic needs? These are very different problems.

Relationships. "I keep choosing the wrong people." Why? What keeps attracting you to the same kind of relationship? What do you overlook at the beginning? What have you come to believe is normal? What are you afraid will happen if you say no?

Health. You lose the weight and gain it back. What does your day actually look like? How much sleep are you getting? What food is available where you live, and what can you afford? What did your family teach you about eating? Is the plan a fit for the life you are actually living?

Work. Somebody good keeps struggling in their organization. What if the person is fine and the system is the problem? Is that true anywhere in your work, church, or family?

Your decisions. What assumptions have you built things on that you have never even questioned?

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What Am I Building My Life Upon?

Jesus spoke about two men who built houses, one on rock and one on sand (Matthew chapter 7). The same storm came to both. One house stood and the other fell. The difference was underneath - the foundation - and the storm revealed it.

I do not mean this only spiritually, although that is where it begins. What are my decisions built on? My relationships? My financial life? My health? My work?

What is my life built on right now?

What have I never examined?

Closing

Do not stop just because you found something that is true. Make sure you have gone deep enough to understand what that truth is standing on.

If you are comfortable, tell Kahu Phil in the comments about something you discovered by asking one more question. You do not have to put private business on the internet - maybe just: "I realized I stopped too soon."

Explore the wider Rotten Fencepost Principle at keaupuniakeakua.faith/rotten-fencepost.

Aloha, God bless,

Kahu Phil Stephens

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